

Tab 1

Unmasking Deception: Whistleblowing and the Fight Against the Tobacco Industry

Nicotine addiction has been recognized as one of the most preventable causes of death, yet the tobacco industry continues to rebrand and develop new strategies to maintain its influence. From the mid-20th century to the present, corporations have hidden authentic research, manipulated public opinion, and targeted vulnerable communities—especially the youth—through friendly marketing and rebranding. These tactics have caused the global tobacco health crisis, where millions have suffered from this preventable disease despite the numerous awareness campaigns and regulatory laws. *The Insider* briefly shows this struggle by uncovering the story of the whistleblower who exposed the hidden truths of the tobacco industry. This essay argues that whistleblowing, in both the past and present, is a vital act of advocacy against corporate deception that safeguards public health through courage and accountability.

Both historically and today, we have seen corporations manipulating the public perception of nicotine and its true effects. Reports from the World Health Organization (WHO) and the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) have shown that vaping among youth has “surged worldwide”, even with the declines in traditional tobacco use. A review by Xue et al. (2024) found that 10.2% of youth worldwide are users of electronic nicotine delivery systems (ENDS), aka e-cigarettes. This clearly shows how the industry is targeting adolescents. *The Insider* mirrors these circumstances in the boardroom scene, for example, where the executives refuse to air Wigand’s data for fear of lawsuits from the industry. This constant tactic of suppression is simply a pattern of deception, in addition to how they have rebranded their products as “safer alternatives” to smoking traditional tobacco. Social campaigns and appealing flavors may support this claim, but it is clear that this is all a transition into the youth market. Scholarly sources such as *The Lancet Oncology* (2022) confirm that the tobacco industry continues to expand its marketplace under the perception of a compromise, hoping for addiction rather than abstinence.

Whistleblowing is a crucial act in revealing the hidden dangers that many industries attempt to keep unknown. In *The Insider*, Wigand risks his career and personal safety to make the facts known about his company within the tobacco business. While CBS was trying to censor his evidence about nicotine manipulation and public deception, he continued facing corporate intimidation. Data from the WHO from one survey found that one in five fifteen-year-olds in Europe, Central Asia, and Canada have recently used e-cigarettes. Alongside this, Belon et al. (2024) further challenge the false claims made by the industry through discrediting industry-funded studies about their products, stating that the research was not from a credible source but rather an attempt to further back up their false claims with false data. Both the film and modern scholarly research emphasize the impact of whistleblowing and how it can be used as a defense against industry manipulation. From the courage of individuals such as Wigand, we have begun a global movement for truth-telling and counterbalancing corporate deception both inside and outside of the tobacco industry.

Nicotine addiction has a devastating human cost that is even larger within the youth and vulnerable communities. WHO (2023) reported over 8 million nicotine-related deaths annually, with 1.3 million of those cases being caused by secondhand smoke. Other studies show that

tobacco use among 13-15-year-olds is nine times more common than among adults. Mann presents the personal consequences of whistleblowing, such as isolation, as a symbol of the psychological pressure of confronting the unbalanced systems. His suffering in the film—and in real life at the time—mirrors the silent struggles of many others who are caught in the endless addiction cycle that nicotine can cause. Biles et al. (2025) confirm that the youth market is the most vulnerable to addictive substances, as well as the misinformation and manipulation that is present in today's society. As a result of connecting Wigand's personal sacrifice with the other millions of youth cases worldwide, we can integrate whistleblowing into our personal lives and make it both an individual and societal act of resistance against these monopolies and industries.

The persistence of nicotine addiction shows how deeply corporations influence our public health outcomes. While awareness of the true dangers of nicotine use is widespread, industries continue to adapt their strategies and marketing to target more vulnerable populations. Looking ahead, stronger regulation, ethical research, and more awareness advocacy will be essential in fighting this health crisis. Personally, I believe this issue is evidence of how easily we can prevent tobacco-related harm and stop corporations from prioritizing profits over truth-telling. The lesson is clear: individuals, scholars, policymakers, and everyday people must support these whistleblowers and demand honesty from our corporations. If addiction can be rebranded, then the reality must be displayed with equal force. The future of our public health depends not only on knowing the facts but defending them. Together, we can ensure a safer environment for our future generations without the deception of these corrupted corporations.

Works Cited

Belon, A. P., Nieuwendyk, L., Allen, T., Worrell, M., & Nykiforuk, C. I. J. (2024). Effective interventions to prevent youth vaping behaviours: A rapid review. *BMJ Open*, 15(1), e092380. <https://doi.org/10.1136/bmjopen-2024-092380>

Biles, J., Kornhaber, R., Irwin, P., Schineanu, A., Sookraj-Baran, M., & Cleary, M. (2025). Perspectives, motivations, and experiences of adolescents and young adults using nicotine vapes: A qualitative scoping review. *Health Promotion International*, 40(2), daaf007. <https://doi.org/10.1093/heapro/daaf007>

Chadi, N., & Levy, S. (2021). Youth vaping: A review and update on global epidemiology, physical and behavioural health risks. *European Journal of Pediatrics*, 180(3), 689–699. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s00431-021-04220-x>

The Insider [Film]. (1999). Directed by Michael Mann. Touchstone Pictures.

World Health Organization. (2023). WHO report on the global tobacco epidemic, 2023: Protect people from tobacco smoke (9th ed.). World Health Organization. <https://www.who.int/publications/i/item/9789240077164>

World Health Organization Europe. (2024). Concerning trends in adolescent substance use: WHO Europe report on alcohol, e-cigarettes, and cannabis. World Health Organization Regional Office for Europe. <https://www.who.int/europe/news/item/25-04-2024-alcohol--e-cigarettes--cannabis--concerning-trends-in-adolescent-substance-use--shows-new-who-europe-report>

Xue, J., Chen, J., & Xu, X. (2024). A global prevalence of electronic nicotine delivery systems (ENDS) use among school and college students: A systematic review and meta-analysis. *BMC Public Health*, 24, 20858. <https://doi.org/10.1186/s12889-024-20858-2>

Intro / Conclusion

Introduction

Michael Mann's *The Insider* (1999) presents whistleblowing